

A planner app that breaks big tasks into manageable daily tasks

Topic Description

Many users struggle with both planning and managing their tasks, especially in a planner app context. When having to balance many different tasks and responsibilities, the issues users may come across can negatively impact their productivity, contrary to what a planner application should foster.

Our overarching topic is *to design a planner application that ultimately breaks down big tasks into smaller, more manageable daily tasks*. Producing a consistent framework — one that does not overwhelm but rather promotes both progress and a sense of accomplishment — through small-scale, measurable achievements will help mitigate any conflicts users have with current planner app setups.

Introduction

Upon the completion of research within both Phase 1 and 2, Phase 3 had us developing design solutions based upon our understanding of user needs within a planner application. Our first phase delved on pain points of existing models, brought to our attention through the construction of usability studies. Within Phase 2, focus groups were held to further deepen our understanding towards the users' perspective. These phases held prior to our designing shone light on key issues: users seek flexibility, a clear feedback system, and straightforward tools that will both sustain and support their planning aspirations.

The goal to reach within Phase 3 is to package our knowledge of user needs, pain points, and gained knowledge of the human experience into an application concept that works. Through holding co-design workshops and subsequent team brainstorming sessions, what has resulted is two concepts that were made with these issues in mind. This report as a whole delves on the process of both the creation and analysis of these designs, and how they build toward our overall goal for a better user experience.

Study Overview

Our goals within Phase 3 were to construct design concepts of a potential planner application via collaboration and team brainstorming.

Co-design sessions were conducted by each team member, each working alongside a participant as they underwent the creative process. Pre-interview questions, sketching activities, and post-activities were done to ultimately capture the desires and requests from the users perspective.

This was subsequently followed by a team brainstorming session. We conducted a “brain dump”, listing and organizing all our gained insights and understandings onto a Miro board. We identified overarching themes such as “Personalization”, “Emotions & Goals”, “Pain Points”, “Features Liked in Sketches”, etc. These themes were key for us to further pinpoint what is desired amongst users, aiding in our design ideation.

Lastly, each team member constructed their own sketches of a planner application, utilizing previously acquired understanding of what works. We then reconvened to critique and select the two strongest sketches that reflect good design methodologies based on the information we have gathered.

Design Ideation Process

For Phase 3, our team developed a structured design ideation process involving brainstorming variations, co-design methods and each team member's concept sketch. Our earlier work—usability testing, focus groups and thematic coding—identified several pain points users faced throughout planning: Difficulty breaking down large goals into daily steps, cluttered interfaces and a strong desire for clarity and personalization. These initial findings shaped how our team synthesized data in Phase 3 brainstorming— ensuring all generated ideas were grounded in validating user needs rather than assumptions.

Co-Design Methods Utilized

To begin our ideation process, each team member conducted a co-design session with two distinct users. Participants were recruited through peer outreach, representing a diverse mix of users varying in gender, workloads and experiences with digital planners. Each user then completed a consistent three-part structure:

- **Pre-interview questions** about their current planning habits
- **A 10-minute design activity** where we had users sketch their ideal planner apps
- **A post-interview reflection** to identify the key design features they wanted

These sessions generated high quality qualitative data captured through participant-created sketches. ([Raw Data Design Sketches](#))

The co-design allowed our team to directly involve users by integrating their input into the design process. Since users know their needs best, our co-design reduced assumptions. Users produced sketches which featured daily tasks cards, progress rings, stress sliders, goal breakdowns, simple layouts, side-by-side task/schedule views, and strong reminder features.

Our thematic analysis of the co-design data identified recurring patterns of:

- Preferences for simple daily layouts
- Stress-reduction tools
- Clear daily task breakdown
- Visual progress tracking
- Unified scheduling/task systems

Our team then translated our patterns into expert design considerations which allowed for our team to steer away from individual preferences to broader design principles. Additionally, each team member developed a concept sketch to interpret both the co-design insight and recurring themes that bridged the gap between raw user input and expert refinement.

Brainstorming Method Utilized

To continue our ideation process, our team chose the **Brain Dump** method for its ease in generating quality & speedy design outputs. Brain dumping served as the primary technique for our team's brainstorming—Using this method, our team quickly generated a large volume of design ideas that captured participants' pain points, user wants, features users liked in sketches, emotions, goals, personalization and design opportunities. After brainstorming the first round of design opportunities, our team then went back to our data to extract direct quotes from all participants to support the established themes.

Example participant quotes gathered during our sessions:

- “Let us do custom designs like wallpapers without it using too much energy
- “I wish it showed daily tasks better instead of a monthly view and a weekly view.
- “Templates for repeated routines.”
- “Tasks automatically shift to the next day.”
- “Make it easier to set daily goals and tasks.”
- “I shut down when tasks are too large.”
- “Layout what you need to do for the day.”

Captured virtually through sticky notes, the Brain Dump helped our team externalize our user insight developed throughout Phase 3. This method was chosen for its fast, flexible and ability to naturally align with the co-design data collected. Color was integrated throughout our brain dump to visually enhance, provide engagement, separate ideas and improve overall readability. Color however, was not used as an analytical tool or tied to categorization—serving only as an organizational tool. Early patterns from Phase 1 & 2 revealed recurring themes depicting users’ desire for simplicity, daily clarity, personalization, automatic rollover, and better goal-breakdown tools.

Brainstorming Summary

Our team then synthesized findings from Phase 1 & 2, the co-design sessions, and our developmental concept sketches to generate high design opportunities. Through our use of our Brain dump session, it was revealed several key themes across all users:

- **Focus on Daily Clarity**
Users consistently called for daily tasks shown immediately. Clarity was emphasized as users revealed a need for simplified layouts that avoided monthly or weekly clutter. “Today’s tasks,” “next important step,” and “clean layouts” appeared repeatedly.
- **Breaking Down Large Goals**
Users valued features such as progress bars, timelines, goal checkpoints, and automatic breakdowns of big tasks into smaller steps
- **Personalization & Customization**
Users wanted tools that made the app feel more personalized such as custom colors, themes, wallpapers, widgets, simple layouts, and stressed-based workload adjustments.
- **Smart Reminders and Automation**
Day-before reminders, Sunday weekly overviews, timed reminders and auto-rollovers were frequently requested.
- **Unified Planning System**
Users wanted tasks, schedules, and goals to appear together in one place—often asking for a side-by-side layout—to reduce switching through screens.

Across all concepts, the shared direction emphasized stress reduction, simplification of daily planning, strong progress feedback, and personalization.

[View Full Brain Dump](#)



Design Brief

Goals of a new application:

The Goal of the proposed planner system is to create a flexible, adaptive, and emotionally supportive planning experience for users. This will allow them to transform large, intimidating

goals into manageable daily tasks. Building on our phase 1 data analysis and phase 2 user insights, this app will prioritize simplicity, motivation, and personalization. It aims to reduce the mental effort required to plan while maintaining enough structure to help users feel confident and in control of their time.

The design will encourage consistent use by presenting clear progression visualization, quick task adjustments, and soft reminders that support rather than overwhelm. It should feel like an assistant, not an obligation. With a goal to guide users towards consistent small wins for long-term growth.

Our team will aim to build a planner that lowers user's stress, supports their daily progress with clear steps, allows the structure to match their real schedules and supports motivation with visible progress and small wins.

Needs / Opportunities / Pain Points addressed

Some user needs and pain points that caught our attention are:

Users want planning applications that are **flexible, simple, and goal-oriented**, yet some users struggle with **motivation fluctuations and stress from overplanning**. Some users shared that “I start strong but lose steam if I don’t get reminders,” while “planning stresses me out more initially,” indicating this conflict between needs.

Another pain point users shared about is **time management**—many spend more time thinking about tasks rather than focusing on task completion: “I spend more time thinking about planning than doing tasks.”

Participants also called for features to **visualize progress, adapt to real-life changes, and support both digital and physical planning habits**. One user made clear that “if I can change my plan easily, then I’ll stick with it,” emphasizing the need to be flexible. Others pointed to the encouragement gained from viewing progress that “crossing them off gives me a sense of achievement,” indicating that visual reinforcement keeps them committed to the process. They want to be more efficient and come up with customized features like reusable tasks and reminders.

Major Themes & User Needs	Opportunities/What We Learned	Pain points
Need for Flexibility	Users struggle when plans change.	Include auto-rescheduling and drag-and-drop task reordering.

Motivation Loss	Users lose interest after early progress.	Add streaks, badges, or progress bars for positive reinforcement.
Cognitive Overload	Users spend too much time setting up planners.	Streamline onboarding and daily entry to under one minute.
Stress from Over-Planning	Users feel anxious when tasks pile up visually.	Limit visible task clutter and highlight only daily priorities.
Inconsistency	Users abandon tools they can't customize.	Enable personalized reminders, colors, and layouts.

Based on these observations, an application might be beneficial to the user if it offers the following:

- **Flexible and adaptive planning structures** that adjust to deadlines, life events, and user habits.
- **Goal-oriented features** that allow visual understanding of progress towards the achievement of objectives.
- **Lightweight reminders and automations** that reduce mental load and increase motivation.
- **Templates with tasks that can be customized** and reused to reduce repeated planning.

The Design Concepts

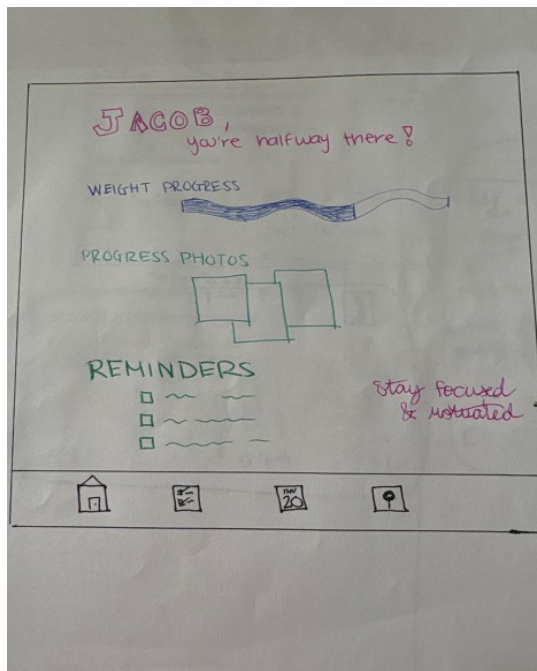
As a group, we reviewed our sketches and the patterns we saw across user feedback from all phases. The strongest patterns were the need for daily clarity, support for planning goals, and layouts that reduce the overcrowded apps. Users repeated these same points in our interviews, usability testing, and co-design sessions. These patterns guided the shared concept we selected.

The shared concept is a daily focused planner that presents one clear view of the day. It centers on progress cues, a short list of reminders, and a layout that holds tasks and schedules together. We chose this direction because users asked for a structure that removes clutter and helps them understand what they need to do without searching through multiple screens.

Across phases, users asked for three main needs. They wanted a planner that stays simple. They wanted support when goals feel large. They wanted daily information in one place. These needs shaped the design direction we agreed on as a team.

The sketch below shows this direction in a mobile layout. The screen begins with a greeting that acknowledges the user. Under the greeting, the sketch presents progress feedback and a section for tracking goal photos. These help users stay aware of their progress in a visual way. The reminders section organizes the next steps for the day. The navigation row at the bottom groups

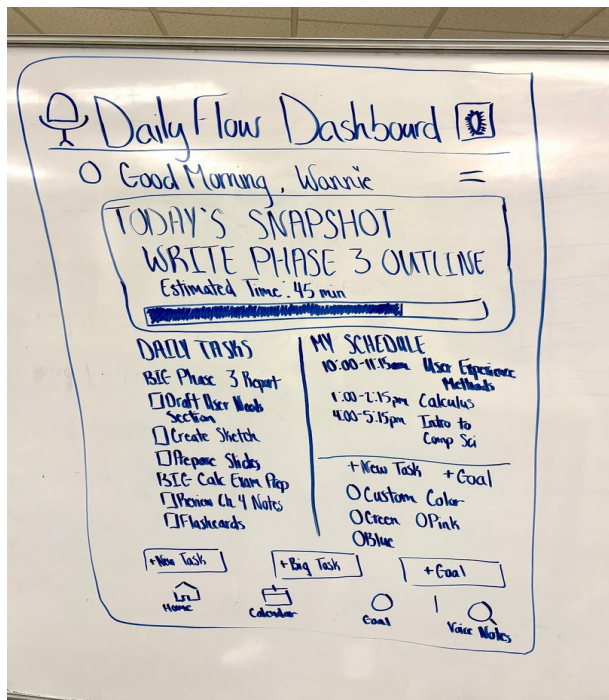
the main functions in one location. This structure follows the feedback that focused on clarity and reduced effort.



We selected this structure because users asked for a home screen that stays focused on today. User feedback showed frustration with long lists, crowded screens, and layouts that force back and forth movement across menus. The sketch addresses these issues by placing daily information into a single, readable space.

We also used the concept summary from our earlier document to support this direction. The summary includes the Daily Flow Dashboard, a breakdown feature for large goals, and a structure that can present tasks and schedules side by side. These ideas surfaced often in the co-design sessions and aligned closely with the themes in our Phase 1 and Phase 2 findings. They fit what users told us about stress, time pressure, and the need for clean layouts.

This second sketch supports the same direction. The second sketch below reflects the feedback users gave us about wanting easy symbols, clear labels, and minimal switching between pages. It fits the same focus on daily clarity and structured progress



We agreed that this concept will stay consistent across different screen sizes. The layout will be able to fit the device, but the core structure stays the same. The user always sees the most relevant information at the top, followed by the progress and reminders. This will support mobile, tablet, and larger screens while keeping the same flow.

As a group, we selected the Daily Flow Dashboard concept by staying close to the themes we observed. Users asked for a planner that helps break big goals into smaller steps. They asked for a clear starting point each day. They asked for fewer distractions and fewer screens. The Daily Flow Dashboard reflects these needs by prioritizing the structure, progress awareness, and reduced clutter. Each part of the layout ties back to comments we heard from users and patterns in our data across phases.

Users also asked for space to view progress in a visual way, and one user said, “I understand my progress better when I can see it.” This led us to include progress feedback in the concept by using different shapes and photos. We kept the design simple, so the progress information supports the user instead of distracting them.

As a group, we stayed focused on the same needs across Phase 1 and Phase 2, and our co-design sessions. Users wanted a planner that reduces stress, supports smaller steps, and keeps daily information clear, and these needs shaped the direction of our design. The Daily Flow Dashboard, the progress section, the reminders section, and the navigation row reflect these findings through a layout that is direct, responsive across all devices, and centered on the main tasks and progress of the day. This direction connects our design choices to the data from our interviews in Phase 1, our testing sessions in Phase 2, and our co-design work.

The Rationale

The final design concept focuses on clarity, simplicity, and adaptability because these were the strongest and most consistent needs identified throughout Phases 1 and 2. In both the focus groups and the usability study, users reported feeling overwhelmed by planner apps that present too many tasks at once or require navigating through several screens to understand what needs attention for the day. They expressed a preference for interfaces that highlight only essential information and reduce the mental effort of planning. To address this, the design centers on a Daily Flow screen that shows only today's schedule, tasks, progress indicators, and one active goal. This structure lowers cognitive load and supports users who want a more manageable planning experience.

Another consistent pattern across the data was difficulty breaking large goals into smaller actions. Users described challenges with converting long term objectives into daily steps they could complete without stress. The design responds to this need by integrating a Smart Goal Breakdown feature that automatically generates smaller, achievable pieces of a larger goal. The Adaptive Auto Rollover feature also prevents tasks from building up visually or mentally by moving unfinished tasks to the next suitable day. This reflects the importance of flexibility identified in both earlier research phases.

Motivation also played a significant role in user needs. Participants often lost interest when progress was not visible or when incomplete tasks stacked up over time. The design incorporates motivation cues such as progress rings, daily encouragement messages, and simple animations to maintain momentum. These elements support consistent use and help users feel rewarded for continuous progress.

Personalization emerged as another meaningful expectation. Users preferred tools that felt tailored to their habits but did not want interfaces that required extensive setup. The design includes light personalization features such as simple color themes, space adjustments, and optional widgets. These options provide comfort and familiarity without adding complexity.

Overall, the design is structured to be simple, flexible, and supportive. It responds directly to the needs identified in user research by providing a planning experience that reduces stress, highlights achievable daily actions, and maintains user motivation through visible progress and gentle guidance.

Decision Ideas

As a group, we linked each design decision to the patterns we saw in Phases 1 and 2 and to the insights from our co-design sessions. Our goal was to build a concept that responds to real needs, not assumptions.

In Phase 1, users told us they feel overwhelmed when planners display long lists of tasks or large goals with no structure, and they said they stop planning when the layout feels crowded or when it is hard to understand what needs to happen today. This pushed us toward a daily focused design, so we shaped the home screen around one clear question, which is what users need to see right now, and this is why the concept keeps the day at the center.

In Phase 1, it helped us identify usability issues that shaped our design direction. Users struggled with the hidden controls, were unclear about how to navigate through the apps, and made frequent mistakes when editing or completing tasks. They also had trouble finding basic features, and many expected easier actions, such as swiping to delete or clear edit buttons. These issues showed us that the users need an easy-to-follow navigation and visible controls. This guided our decision to use a clean navigation row, visible labels, and a layout that removes extra steps. The daily flow dashboard reflects this by having daily actions and the progress at the center of the screen, which supports users who want a straightforward path through the app. These insights from phase 1 gave us our foundation since they showed us where the app creates trouble for first-time users, and where a new design needs to reduce the mistakes

Phase 2 gave us insight into how people plan, what discourages them, and what supports their motivation. Users talked about stress from changing schedules, losing interest when progress is hard to see, and feeling overwhelmed when planners show too much at once. They also shared how they break goals into steps and why they will abandon planning tools when the layouts do not match their real routines. These findings helped with our decision to keep the layout simple, highlight the daily priorities, and include progress feedback that supports momentum. This reflects the major themes from Phase 2, which are focused on flexibility, motivating users, and keeping the structure clear and easy to follow.

The co-design sessions added more insight. Users wanted to see tasks and the schedule together. They wanted fewer screen shifts and a clear picture of how their time connects with their tasks. We used this feedback to support a layout that can hold both pieces of information on the same page when space allows. The ideas listed in the design concept summary, such as the Daily Flow Dashboard and the side-by-side structure, fit these needs and appeared in many of the user sketches.

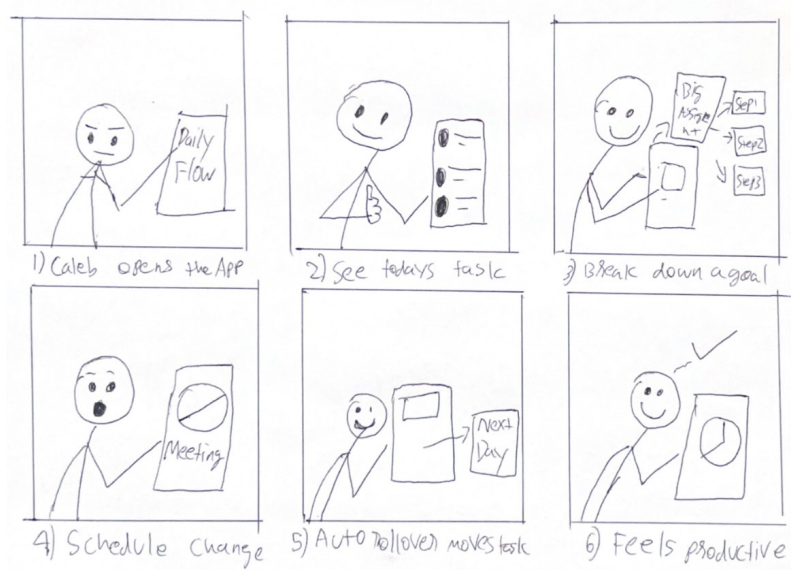
Scenario & storyboards

Persona: Caleb Reed (Student Persona)

Scenario 1: Caleb Reed

Caleb begins his morning by opening the app before class, where the Daily Flow screen immediately shows only today's tasks and schedule, giving him a clear and uncluttered starting point. He selects a long term assignment and uses the Smart Goal Breakdown feature to turn it into smaller, manageable steps for the week, reviewing the list and making one quick adjustment before confirming. Later in the day his schedule changes when a meeting is cancelled, so he uses the Auto Rollover feature to shift one unfinished task to the next suitable day. The app updates the rest of his plan automatically, keeping his day organized without extra work. At the end of the day Caleb checks the progress ring and feels satisfied that he stayed productive without dealing with unnecessary screens or task clutter.

Storyboard

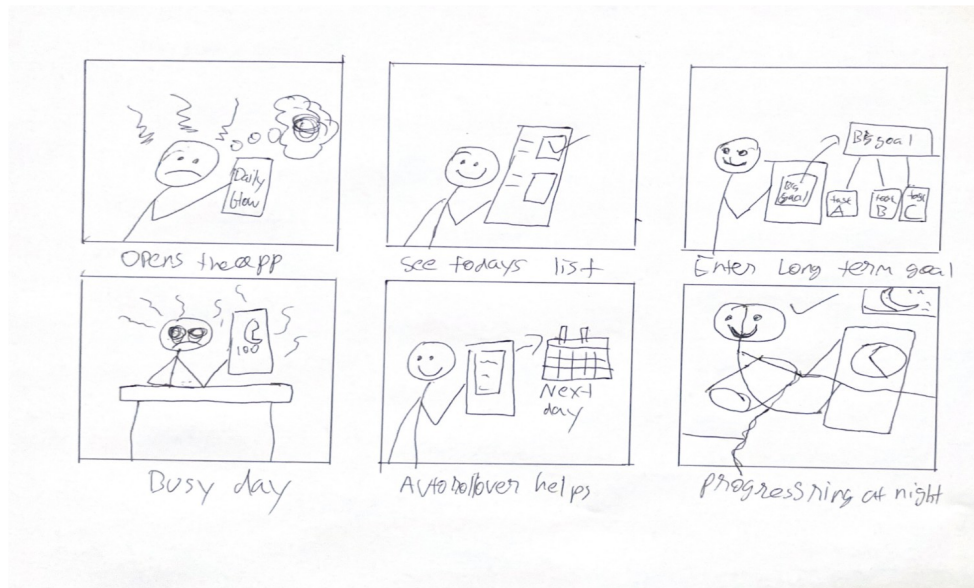


Persona: Daniel Reyes (Busy Student/Worker Persona)

Scenario 2: Daniel Reyes

Daniel starts his week by opening the app on a busy morning, seeing only today's tasks on the Daily Flow screen which helps him focus without feeling overwhelmed. He adds a new long term goal for his biology course, and the Smart Goal Breakdown tool automatically generates small steps he can complete throughout the week, allowing him to begin immediately instead of figuring out where to start. Midweek he falls behind on one task because of work, but the Auto Rollover feature moves the unfinished item to the next appropriate day and keeps the list manageable. That night Daniel checks the progress ring and sees steady advancement, which reassures him that he is still on track and encourages him to continue using the app.

Storyboard -



Our New Design (Pitch)

Our design is built around the concept that people don't need another unnecessarily complex and complicated planner app—They need something that is simple and actually helps get stuff done, rather than feel like another task. During our research and co-design sessions, users consistently said that existing apps feel cluttered, overwhelming, or just too time-consuming to manage. So instead of giving users another calendar they have to babysit, we designed a system that works with them and adjusts as their day changes.

The design focuses on the **Daily Flow Dashboard**, where users only see what matters on that day. This includes things like tasks, schedule, and progress. Nothing else extra or unnecessary. Features like smart goal breakdown, auto rollover task, and stress slider make the planner adaptive instead of overconsuming and rigid. Keeping everything visible in one place removes the distractions that users said made other apps stressful to use. The design avoids extra tabs, hidden features, or overwhelming layouts. Users should be able to open the app and immediately understand what needs attention.

We also included features based directly on user feedback across phases, especially around goal setting and motivation. Many users said they struggle to break down big goals into smaller, achievable steps and often lose motivation when progress is not clear or rewarding. To address that we included the **Smart Goal Breakdown** feature, which automatically turns large goals into smaller tasks so users don't have to figure out where to start. The **Auto Rollover** system keeps planning flexible by moving unfinished items to the next appropriate day instead of letting tasks stack up and feel overwhelming. There are other various motivational features like progress rings and encouragement messages.

Overall, this design pulls together everything we learned throughout the project. It focuses on clarity, flexibility, and helpful automation so the app can support users throughout their day rather than becoming another task they need to manage.

Conclusion

Wrapping up the final phase, As a team we took everything the users struggled with in planner apps and turned it into a design that fits what user needs. Throughout the earlier phases, users informed us planning tools felt overwhelming, cluttered, and as if another task that needed to be managed. For phase 3, we focused on designing an application that makes planning feel easier and reduces stress. Every design choice was influenced by feedback, co-design sketches, and the recurring patterns across participants. The design idea to build a planner application that makes sense for how people plan their day.

Looking throughout the phases, the research played a huge role in shaping the final concept. If we didn't ask users for their input or test ideas with them, the design probably would have ended up feeling like every other planner out there... Instead, the final result feels more intentional. It focuses on showing only what matters on that current day, breaking down goals into smaller steps, and adapting when tasks don't go as planned. The concept is simple, clear, and flexible, which are the same qualities users asked for from the beginning. Based on everything we learned in this project, we believe this direction has real potential and is worth moving forward with because it supports real daily life rather than expecting users to add another thing to their plate.